

years by families that guarded their honor, protected and promoted their family interests, and built and maintained family fortunes.

Later, during the days of the empire, family fortunes were harder to hold on to—because emperors wanted the money. But that is a long, long story.

For our present purpose, let us just remember that the goal of anyone who wants a family fortune is partly to protect himself from the state. Families maintain their own resources largely because they don't want to have to rely on the generosity of the state. We've already seen several state-run pension systems go bust. Health care systems, notably that of Britain, are often subject to bad management, money shortages, and institutional failings. As for those who depend on the state for their sustenance, as Jefferson put it, "We should soon want bread."

But that is not the worst of it. History shows that not only is the state an unreliable helpmate, but it can turn into a family's worst enemy.

The aristocrats of France, for example, found themselves practically hunted down as the Revolution turned into the Reign of Terror. The Committee of Public Safety came under the control of Maximilien Robespierre in 1793. He sent some 16,594 people to the guillotine. Their crime? Being in the wrong place at the wrong time.

We don't have to go far to find other examples. The one that leaps to mind is the case of the Jews in Germany and Eastern Europe in the 1930s and 1940s. Government became not just a parasite that took their money, but became their mortal enemy, rounding them up, sending whole families—millions of them—to labor and extermination camps.

The early and mid-twentieth century was a heyday for murderous governments. While the Nazis were preparing their campaigns against Jews, gypsies, subscribers to various religions, homosexuals, half-wits, cripples, democrats, and other groups, the Soviet Union was doing its own ethnic cleansing.

Whole nations were put on trains and shipped east, where they posed no threat to the communist rulers. Business owners and small farmers were systematically persecuted, exiled, imprisoned, or murdered. Anyone who resisted, or might resist, the collectivization of the farms or factories was labeled a "class enemy" and marked for elimination.